

A Christian's Wage

Twice in Luke 6 Jesus tells people they will be paid.

The first comes at the end of the blessings.

Rejoice in that day, and leap for joy, for behold, your reward is great in heaven. (6:23)

The second comes at the end of the passage on loving enemies.

Love your enemies, and do good, and lend, expecting nothing in return, and your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High. (6:35)

Between them sit the woes.

The word is *misthos*. It is not the language of prizes. It is the language of employment – what a hired man is handed at the end of the day, counted out, owed. Luke uses it that way elsewhere: the labourer deserves his wages.

So the promise is not that something extra will be added. It is that there is pay at the end of this, and it has not come yet.

Then the woes.

But woe to you who are rich, for you have received your consolation. (6:24)

The verb is the one a merchant wrote on a receipt: received in full, nothing outstanding. It is not a threat about the future. It says the money has already changed hands.

So the line Jesus draws is not between people who are happy now and people who are sad now. It is between a wage already handed over and a wage still owed.

Go back to the first one and read what it actually says. Your reward is great in heaven.

He gives the size of it. He gives where it is kept. He does not say what it is.

And he tells them to leap for joy about it on the day they are hated, excluded and insulted – glad now about something they have not been given and cannot yet describe.

The second mention does say what.

But love your enemies, and do good, and lend, expecting nothing in return, and your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High, for he is kind to the ungrateful and the evil. (6:35)

Sons of the Most High is not a second promise laid alongside the wage. It is the wage. And Jesus gives the reason in the next clause: because that is what the Most High is like. He is kind to people who will not thank him and do not deserve it.

Lend to someone who will not pay you back, and you have done what God does. The pay for doing what God does is being the kind of person who does it.

Then the line that closes the section.

Be merciful, even as your Father is merciful. (6:36)

The word is *oiktirmon* – compassionate. It is the word the Greek Old Testament uses when God names himself to Moses on the mountain: compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in *hesed*. Jesus takes the description God gave of himself and hands it over as a job description.

This rests on the Greek of Luke 6:36 being the same word the Greek Old Testament uses in Exodus 34:6. It is a reading, not a quotation – Luke does not say he is citing Moses.

The two sayings stand together. The first says the pay is great and does not say what it is. The second says what it is, and it is not something he gives you. It is someone you become.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.